

WHO ARE THE PASHTUNS?

Language Family History Culture Community Identity

The question sounds simple. The answer is not.

The Pashtuns are a major ethnolinguistic community of South and Central Asia, historically associated particularly with Afghanistan and the northwestern regions of present-day Pakistan.¹

They are connected by Pashto, shared cultural traditions, historical relationships, and a wide network of tribal, clan, family, and community identities.

But there is no single experience of being Pashtun.

A Pashtun from a mountain village may experience identity differently from a Pashtun raised in Karachi. A family living in Peshawar may have a different history from one living in Kandahar. A young Pashtun growing up in London or Dubai may have a very different daily life from someone living in Tirah.

Yet all may understand themselves through some form of Pashtun identity. This diversity is essential to understanding the Pashtun world.

A PEOPLE AND A LANGUAGE

Language is one of the most important dimensions of Pashtun identity.

Pashto is an Eastern Iranian language and belongs to the Iranian branch of the Indo-European language family.² It has developed regional varieties and dialects, and its history reflects interaction with neighbouring languages and cultures.

Language, however, does not operate as a perfect boundary.

Not every person with Pashtun ancestry necessarily speaks Pashto fluently. Some Pashtuns grow up speaking Urdu, Dari, English, or another language alongside or instead of Pashto. Others may speak a regional variety that differs considerably from what another Pashtun community speaks.

This means that language and identity are strongly connected, but they should not be treated as exactly the same thing.

A TRIBAL SOCIETY

Traditional Pashtun society has often been organized through tribes, clans, sub-clans, extended families, and local communities. These structures have played important roles in social organization, leadership, alliances, land relationships, marriage, conflict resolution, and community life.³

But “Pashtun tribe” should not be understood as a simple modern biological category.

Tribal histories can contain genealogical traditions, oral histories, political alliances, migrations, and historical changes. Different sources may therefore provide different accounts of the relationships between groups. This is one reason why tribal genealogy must be studied carefully.

A traditional genealogy can be culturally important without being independently verifiable in every detail.

PASHTUN IDENTITY

Ethnic identity is not created by ancestry alone. It can also involve language, family, community, culture, shared memory, historical experience, geography, social relationships, and personal identification.

For Pashtuns, these elements can overlap in different ways. Some people emphasize language. Others emphasize family and tribal affiliation. Others connect identity strongly with cultural traditions. For many, several of these dimensions exist simultaneously.

Identity can therefore be both inherited and lived.

PASHTUNWALI

Pashtunwali is often described in academic and ethnographic literature as a traditional social and ethical framework associated with Pashtun communities. Concepts commonly associated with Pashtunwali include:

Melmastia — hospitality.

Nanawatai — seeking or granting refuge.

Nang — honour.

Badal — reciprocity, justice, or revenge depending on context.

These concepts should not be presented as a universal code followed identically by every Pashtun. Pashtun communities are diverse. Urbanization, education, religion, state institutions, migration, economic change, and modern law have all influenced how traditional social practices are understood and practiced. Tradition changes as societies change.

THE QUESTION OF ORIGIN

One of the most debated questions concerning the Pashtuns is their ancient origin. Pashtun genealogical traditions have connected Pashtuns with different figures and peoples of the ancient world. Historical writers and later traditions have proposed different explanations for Pashtun ethnogenesis.⁴

Some theories have attempted to connect Pashtuns with ancient peoples mentioned in classical or Middle Eastern sources. Others have proposed relationships with Iranian, Central Asian, or South Asian populations.

These theories should not be presented as established fact without strong evidence. The historical formation of an ethnic group is usually more complicated than tracing a modern population to one ancient ancestor. Languages change, communities migrate, political identities develop, groups form alliances, people intermarry, names change, and identities can expand or transform over centuries.

For this reason, the question “Who were the first Pashtuns?” cannot simply be answered with a single name from antiquity. The evidence is more complex.

PASHTUNS AND HISTORY

Pashtun communities have participated in the history of Afghanistan, the northwestern Indian subcontinent, and the wider region for centuries. Different Pashtun dynasties, tribal confederations, political leaders, soldiers, scholars, poets, merchants, farmers, and communities have played different roles at different times.

But Pashtun history should not be reduced to political rulers. It is also the history of ordinary families: farmers, traders, poets, religious scholars, teachers, craftsmen, migrants, students, and communities adapting to changing political and economic environments. This broader perspective makes the history more human.

PASHTUNS ACROSS THE MODERN MAP

Modern national borders divide parts of the historic Pashtun geographical world. Large Pashtun populations live in Afghanistan and Pakistan, while Pashtun communities also exist elsewhere through migration and diaspora.⁵

Cities have become particularly important. Peshawar, Quetta, Kabul, Kandahar, Jalalabad, Islamabad, Karachi, Dubai, London, and many other cities have become part of contemporary Pashtun life. The Pashtun world is therefore no longer defined only by rural or mountainous geography. It is increasingly urban and global.

THE MODERN PASHTUN

The modern Pashtun identity exists within a rapidly changing world. Pashtuns are participating in education, medicine, engineering, science, technology, business, finance, government, arts, literature, sports, research, and entrepreneurship.

A young Pashtun can be connected to an ancestral village while working in a global technology company. A family can preserve Pashto poetry while its children study artificial intelligence. A person can respect cultural traditions while living according to modern professional and educational values.

These are not necessarily opposing identities. They can exist together.

WHO GETS TO DEFINE A PEOPLE?

Perhaps the most important lesson is that no single person should be expected to define an entire people. Pashtun identity is too diverse for that.

A historian can study the past, a linguist can study language, an anthropologist can study society, a family can preserve its memories, and an individual can describe personal identity. Each perspective contributes something different. Understanding a people therefore requires more than one source. It requires listening to history, scholarship, memory, language, and lived experience at the same time.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR AN ORAKZAI

For me, understanding the Pashtuns provides a wider context for understanding Orakzai identity. Orakzai is not an isolated name; it exists within a broader Pashtun historical and cultural landscape.

But being part of a larger people does not erase the identity of an individual tribe. The wider story gives context. The local story gives detail. The family story gives meaning. And personal experience gives the story a human voice. That is where my own journey begins.

WHO ARE WE?

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Before asking, “Why am I Orakzai?” I had to ask a larger question: “What does it mean to be Pashtun?” The answer I have found is not one sentence. It is a combination of language, family, memory, history, culture, community, and personal choice. And perhaps that is what makes identity meaningful. It cannot always be reduced to a definition. Sometimes it has to be lived.